

Day 48 — TNPSC Group 2A Study Material

Part A – General Studies: History of Tamil Society and Related Archaeological Discoveries

READING MATERIAL

Covers two of Tamil Nadu's most significant excavation sites — Arikamedu (a Roman-era trade port) and Keezhadi (early literacy evidence) — plus a few core Sangam-era political facts. Real exam evidence favours testing exact site-to-finding pairings and common Chera/Chola mix-ups.

Q: Real exam: What evidence has been found at Arikamedu, and which excavation method was used there?

A: Evidence of a planned town, warehouses, and ring wells has been found at Arikamedu (near Puducherry) — confirmed by a real exam question. Sir Mortimer Wheeler excavated Arikamedu using the scientific stratigraphy (soil-layer) method — also confirmed by a separate real exam question.

Q: Real exam: Who actually ruled the Kaveri delta from Uraiyur — and what's the common mix-up?

A: The CHOLAS ruled the Kaveri delta, with their capital at Uraiyur — a real exam flagged 'The Cheras ruled over the Kaveri delta with capital Uraiyur' as FALSE; the Cheras actually ruled the Kerala region (capital at Vanji/Karur), a different dynasty entirely from the Cholas.

Q: Real exam: What was the Chola royal emblem, and what did their coins feature?

A: The Chola emblem was the TIGER. They issued square copper coins bearing images of the tiger — confirmed by a real exam question.

Q: Real exam: Does the Sangam Age have its roots in the Bronze Age?

A: NO — a real exam flagged this claim as FALSE. The Sangam Age is generally associated with the Iron Age / early historic period (roughly 300 BCE-300 CE), not the earlier Bronze Age.

Q: Real exam: What evidence from the Keezhadi (Keeladi) excavation suggests people in 6th century BC were literate?

A: Pots found at Keezhadi bear Tamizhi script engraved on them, AND most of these pots were inscribed with letters AFTER the pot had already dried (not before firing) — both confirmed true by a real exam question, together forming the literacy evidence.

Q: Real exam: Which Tamil moral/wisdom text is also referred to as 'Velaan Vedham'?

A: Proverbs (the collected Tamil proverbs) — confirmed by a real exam question, distinguishing it from Thirukkural, Aarakkovai, and Naladiyaar offered as distractors.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. Evidence of a planned town, warehouses, and ring wells has been found at which excavation site?

- A. Keezhadi
- B. Arikamedu ✓**
- C. Adichanallur
- D. Poompuhar

Explanation: Arikamedu. [medium, question-bank-2025]

2. Sir Mortimer Wheeler used which excavation method/technique at Arikamedu?

- A. Carbon dating
- B. Stratigraphy (soil-layer analysis) ✓**
- C. Aerial photography
- D. Ground-penetrating radar

Explanation: Stratigraphy (soil-layer analysis). [medium, question-bank-2022]

3. Which dynasty actually ruled the Kaveri delta, with their capital at Uraiyur?

- A. Cheras
- B. Cholas ✓**
- C. Pandyas
- D. Pallavas

Explanation: Cholas. [medium, question-bank-2025]

4. What was the Chola royal emblem, featured on their square copper coins?

- A. The fish
- B. The bow
- C. The tiger ✓**
- D. The lion

Explanation: The tiger. [medium, question-bank-2025]

5. The Sangam Age is generally dated to which broad period?

- A. Bronze Age
- B. Iron Age / early historic period ✓**
- C. Stone Age
- D. Medieval period

Explanation: Iron Age / early historic period. [hard, question-bank-2025]

6. What script is engraved on pots found at the Keezhadi excavation site?

- A. Brahmi
- B. Tamizhi ✓**
- C. Devanagari
- D. Grantha

Explanation: Tamizhi. [medium, question-bank-2026]

7. At Keezhadi, most pots were inscribed with letters:

- A. Before the pot was fired
- B. After the pot had dried ✓**
- C. While the clay was still wet on the wheel
- D. By the buyer after purchase

Explanation: After the pot had dried. [hard, question-bank-2026]

8. Which Tamil moral text is also known as 'Velaan Vedham'?

- A. Thirukkural
- B. Aarakkovai
- C. Proverbs ✓**
- D. Naladiyaar

Explanation: Proverbs. [hard, question-bank-2022]

Part B – Aptitude & Mental Ability: Number Series

READING MATERIAL

Number Series is the final Reasoning skill. Real exam evidence shows 6 distinct underlying patterns: second-difference (difference-of-differences) sequences, sum-of-consecutive-cubes, geometric progression, arithmetic progression, n^2 multiples, and prime-number-squared sequences — recognize the pattern TYPE before trying to compute term-by-term.

Q: Method — sum of consecutive cubes: Find the next term: 9, 35, 91, ?

A: Each term is $n^3 + (n+1)^3$: $1^3 + 2^3 = 1 + 8 = 9$ ✓, $2^3 + 3^3 = 8 + 27 = 35$ ✓, $3^3 + 4^3 = 27 + 64 = 91$ ✓. Next: $4^3 + 5^3 = 64 + 125 = 189$.

Q: Method — second-difference (arithmetic sequence of differences): Fill in the blank: 1, 6, 15, 28, 45, ____, 91.

A: Differences: $6 - 1 = 5$, $15 - 6 = 9$, $28 - 15 = 13$, $45 - 28 = 17$ — these differences themselves increase by 4 each time. Next difference = $17 + 4 = 21$, so the blank = $45 + 21 = 66$. (Check: $91 - 66 = 25 = 21 + 4$ ✓ consistent.)

Q: Method — sequence of squared primes: Find the missing number in the sequence of squared prime numbers: 4 (2^2), 9 (3^2), 25 (5^2), 49 (7^2), ?, 169 (13^2).

A: The base numbers are consecutive primes: 2, 3, 5, 7, 11, 13. The missing term corresponds to $11^2 = 121$. (Caution: the original source rendered this sequence with garbled formatting that looked like plain 3-digit numbers rather than squared primes — always re-derive the actual pattern rather than trusting a confusing transcription.)

Q: Method — simple arithmetic progression (AP) with increasing-by-2 differences: Find the next term: 1, 5, 11, 19, 29, ?

A: Differences: 4, 6, 8, 10 — increasing by 2 each time. Next difference = 12, so next term = $29 + 12 = 41$.

Q: Method — geometric progression (GP): Find the 8th term of 2, 6, 18, 54, ...

A: Common ratio = 3 (each term $\times 3$). Terms: 2, 6, 18, 54, 162, 486, 1458, 4374. The 8th term is 4,374.

Q: Method — plain arithmetic progression, nth term formula: Find the 20th term of 7, 10, 13, ...

A: First term = 7, common difference = 3. nth term = $a + (n-1)d = 7 + (19 \times 3) = 7 + 57 = 64$.

Q: Method — multiples of n^2 : Find the missing number: 3, 12, 27, 48, 75, 108, ____.

A: Each term = $3 \times n^2$ for $n=1, 2, 3, \dots$: $3 \times 1 = 3$, $3 \times 4 = 12$, $3 \times 9 = 27$, $3 \times 16 = 48$, $3 \times 25 = 75$, $3 \times 36 = 108$. Next ($n=7$): $3 \times 49 = 147$.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. Find the next term: 2, 9, 28, 65, 126, ?

A. 215

B. 217 ✓

C. 219

D. 221

Explanation: Each term is $n^3 + 1$: $1^3 + 1 = 2$, $2^3 + 1 = 9$, $3^3 + 1 = 28$, $4^3 + 1 = 65$, $5^3 + 1 = 126$. Next: $6^3 + 1 = 216 + 1 = 217$. [hard, authored]

2. Fill in the blank: 2, 7, 14, 23, 34, ____, 62.

A. 45

B. 47 ✓

C. 49

D. 51

Explanation: Differences: 5, 7, 9, 11 — increasing by 2. Next difference = 13, so blank = $34 + 13 = 47$. (Check: $62 - 47 = 15 = 13 + 2$, consistent.) [medium, authored]

3. Find the next term: 3, 7, 15, 27, 43, ?

A. 61

B. 63 ✓

C. 65

D. 67

Explanation: Differences: 4, 8, 12, 16 — increasing by 4. Next difference = 20, so next term = $43 + 20 = 63$. [medium, authored]

4. Find the 7th term of the GP: 3, 9, 27, 81, ...

A. 1,458

B. 2,187 ✓

C. 2,287

D. 1,987

Explanation: Common ratio 3: 3,9,27,81,243,729,2187. 7th term = 2,187. [medium, authored]

5. Find the 15th term of the AP: 5, 9, 13, 17, ...

A. 59

B. 61 ✓

C. 63

D. 65

Explanation: $a=5$, $d=4$. 15th term = $5+(14 \times 4) = 5+56 = 61$. [easy, authored]

6. Find the missing number: 2, 8, 18, 32, 50, ____.

A. 62

B. 68

C. 72 ✓

D. 78

Explanation: Each term = $2 \times n^2$: $2 \times 1=2$, $2 \times 4=8$, $2 \times 9=18$, $2 \times 16=32$, $2 \times 25=50$. Next ($n=6$): $2 \times 36=72$. [medium, authored]

Part C – General English: Prose: "A Visitor from Distant Lands"

READING MATERIAL

A story about Mani, a village boy near Senji (Villupuram district), who refuses to eat his favourite potato curry after his teacher tells him potatoes are a 'foreign' vegetable — used as a frame to teach the real history of how New World foods like chillies and potatoes reached India via European exploration and trade.

Q: Where is the story set, and who are the two children in it?

A: In a village near Senji, in Villupuram district. The two children are Mani and his sister Selvi.

Q: What food did Mani refuse to eat, and why?

A: Potato curry (his usual favourite dish) — he refused because his TEACHER had told him potatoes are a foreign vegetable, and he wanted to eat only locally-grown food.

Q: Where did Mani's mother get the potatoes from?

A: From the market.

Q: What is the real historical story of the chilli, told within this lesson?

A: Chillies originally grew only in South America, unknown to the rest of the world. Christopher Columbus — while actually searching for a sea route to India to buy black pepper — instead reached South America and discovered the chilli there. Chillies were later brought to India by the Portuguese, first arriving in Goa, where local cooks began incorporating this new spice into their cuisine.

Q: What spice did Indian cooking commonly rely on BEFORE chillies arrived?

A: Black pepper.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. Where is the story "A Visitor from Distant Lands" set?

A. Chennai

B. A village near Senji, Villupuram ✓

C. Madurai

D. Salem

Explanation: A village near Senji, Villupuram district. [medium, web-research]

2. Who are the two children in the story?

A. Ravi and Radha

B. Mani and Selvi ✓

C. Karthik and Meena

D. Vasu and Vani

Explanation: Mani and Selvi. [easy, web-research]

3. What food did Mani refuse to eat?

A. Rice

B. Dosa

C. Potato curry ✓

D. Tomato soup

Explanation: Potato curry. [easy, web-research]

4. Why did Mani say he wouldn't eat potatoes?

A. They were overcooked

B. He was not hungry

C. They were foreign vegetables ✓

D. He didn't like the taste

Explanation: They were foreign vegetables. [medium, web-research]

5. Who told Mani that potatoes are foreign vegetables?

A. His mother

B. His friend

C. His teacher ✓

D. His grandfather

Explanation: His teacher. [medium, web-research]

6. Where did Mani's mother get the potatoes from?

A. Her garden

B. The market ✓

C. A farm

D. The forest

Explanation: The market. [medium, web-research]

7. Christopher Columbus, while searching for a sea route to India to buy which spice, instead discovered South America and the chilli?

A. Cinnamon

B. Black pepper ✓

C. Cloves

D. Cardamom

Explanation: Black pepper. [medium, web-research]

8. Who brought chillies to India, and where did they first arrive?

A. The British, in Madras

B. The Portuguese, in Goa ✓

C. The French, in Pondicherry

D. The Dutch, in Kerala

Explanation: The Portuguese, in Goa. [medium, web-research]